

Edited images

From merging separate images to adding special effects, editing photos can be a fun way to create something new. But edited images are problematic when they present unattainable standards of beauty or body shape as normal, crop out essential information, or are used as “evidence” to claim falsely that something has happened.



△ Judging the risks

Always think critically about the source of the images and the motives that source may have.

Product placement

Look out for product recommendations in user-generated content. Make-up tutorials by vloggers, for example, rarely make it clear that the vlogger is sponsored by the product manufacturers and benefitting financially from promoting it.

Echo chambers

Search engines and social media platforms are set up in a way that means people generally only see one side of the story and rarely encounter anything that disagrees with them. This means that people can end up in a bubble, often known as an “echo chamber.” As a test, it’s worth looking at a friend’s search engine results and social media platforms to see how each person receives ads and news that is tailored to them. Teens can limit the risk of ending up in an echo chamber by seeking out information that challenges their opinion, which can strengthen their own views, as they have to work harder to think about and defend them.

TEEN HINTS

Using search engines effectively

Knowing how to find the most relevant search results when looking for information on the Internet will help ensure you are pointed toward a broad range of trustworthy content. When searching for information online:

- try out more than one search engine as their results might vary
- look for website addresses that end in .com, .gov, or .org
- don’t trust the top results—scroll down to check out more options
- ignore search results that say “sponsored,” “ad,” or “promoted,” as someone has paid for these to be at the top of the list
- be precise—use at least two keywords in the search
- be sure to spell the keywords correctly.



Online peer pressure

As in real life, teens can be pressured by others online to behave in ways that make them feel uncomfortable. Online challenges and dares are when people share a photo or video of themselves doing something unusual and nominate others to do the same. Safe challenges might raise money for charity or ask a funny question. These don’t humiliate or harm anyone, but other dares may cause teens to feel uncomfortable or involve dangerous risks.

▷ No pressure

Making judgments isn’t just about working out what’s true and what isn’t. It also includes making decisions about how to act.

